

The Ideological Congruence Controversy

The Impact of Alternative Measures, Data, and Time Periods on the Effects of Election Rules

G. Bingham Powell, Jr.

University of Rochester, New York

Focusing on the left-right scale as a summary measure of citizens' and representatives' preferences, a growing body of literature has used a variety of approaches and data in measuring positions of citizens and representatives. The most recent studies, contrary to previous ones, show no significant difference between ideological congruence in single member district (SMD) and proportional representation (PR) electoral systems. This article examines the major alternative measurement approaches and data sets, finding that recent results are due to differences in time period, not differences in measurement approach. The associations between election rules and ideological congruence are relatively robust to various measurement approaches, as are estimations of the causal processes shaping ideological congruence. The association between election rules and congruence has declined in the past decade, as shown by all three major approaches, due primarily to convergence toward the median of plurality parties in the SMD elections.

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Just as a scholarly consensus seemed to have been reached on the general effect of election rules—at least the single member district/proportional representation (SMD/PR) distinction—on the ideological congruence between citizens and representatives, this consensus has been challenged by two

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new studies based on new, highly credible data. The current article tries to explain the differences in findings and integrate them into a theoretically consistent perspective.

Since the early 1990s a number of published studies have extended the well-known studies of election rules and vote-seat representation to an examination of the ideological congruence between voters and their representatives. At least in mature democracies, the empirical vote-seat studies (e.g., Lijphart, 1994; Rae, 1967) had demonstrated that proportional representation, multimember district election rules enjoyed a considerable representational advantage over the main alternative, various forms of single member district election rules. The empirical studies of ideological congruence seemed to show a similar, if more variable, advantage for PR in facilitating a better fit between voters, median legislators, and governments in their positions on a right-left dimension of political discourse (Huber & Powell, 1994; Klingeman, Volkens, Bara, Budge, & McDonald, 2006; McDonald & Budge, 2005; McDonald, Mendes, & Budge, 2004; Powell, 2000, 2006; Powell & Vanberg, 2000).

However, two new empirical studies (Blais & Bodet, 2006; Golder & Stramski, 2007) reject these findings and argue that there is no consistent advantage for PR systems in promoting ideological congruence. Interestingly enough, the new studies generally adopt the same theoretical reasoning about the emergence of congruence under PR and SMD that had been previously proposed. They agree that the causal mechanisms creating correspondence are somewhat different under the different systems but find no reason to expect one to be superior to the other. Both studies argue that the new cross-national data provided by the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) project enable superior measurement of citizen and representative congruence. They explicitly suggest that previous findings should be considered superseded by the new ones because of these improved measures.

Measuring Congruence

At the heart of the problem of studying congruence empirically is the need to estimate the positions of citizens and the positions of their representatives on the same scale (Achen, 1977, 1978, demonstrated the problem of trying to compare correlation coefficients or similar standardized measures). This is true if we try to study congruence across districts within a single country. The problem is compounded in cross-national analyses of ideological congruence because it is fairly clear that voters, when asked

about positions on right and left, tend to respond with reference to a local discourse. For that reason we find voters in different countries placing themselves toward the center, even though on substantive grounds their preferences are quite different. Local discourses are composed of somewhat different issues, weighted differently, and most important, the meaning of the center and other positions varies.

The cross-national congruence studies have taken three different approaches to the problem of estimating the distance between citizens and governments. In each case the position of the government is based on the separately estimated positions of the political parties of which it is composed, weighted either by their percentage of legislative seats or their (similar) percentage of cabinet portfolios.

The main approaches to measuring congruence are here summarized as the citizen survey/expert survey approach (*cit-ex*), the party vote/party manifesto approach (*manifesto*), and the citizen identification/citizen perception (*cit-perc*) approach. Each of these has been praised and criticized; each has strengths and weaknesses.

Citizen survey/expert survey. This approach uses citizen surveys that ask citizens to place themselves on a right-left scale to identify the position of the median citizen (or median voter). The median can either be the right-left category including the median or an estimated specific position between categories. The position of the representatives is estimated from surveys of experts on each country, asking them to place the different parties on a right-left scale. All legislators are assumed to be at the position of their party (which is a reasonable approximation in high discipline/cohesion parliamentary democracies, less so elsewhere). The positions of the median legislator and the government are estimated from these party placements. "Congruence" is measured by the distance between the median citizen and the government or median legislator; more distance means less congruence. As differences are measured in each country, the absolute meaning of the right-left position need not be the same, only the width of the scale positions (Huber & Powell, 1994; Powell, 2000, 2006; Powell & Vanberg, 2000).

The great strength of this approach is that the local experts might be best expected to know the "true" positions of the political parties, especially as the surveys usually have a fairly large number of experts. The most fundamental problem in principle is that there is no way to be sure that the local experts and the citizens really have the same things in mind when they assign themselves, or parties, a position such as 3 or 5 on a 10-point scale (also see Budge, 2000). In practice, the study of expert placement and manifesto

placements by McDonald, Mendes, and Kim (2006) also shows that the expert studies do not seem to vary greatly by local context and they seem relatively static across time. Moreover, there have not been too many expert surveys, so these studies assume that party positions are stable within 5 years of the survey, an assumption that can occasionally lead to error.

Party vote/party manifesto. A second, quite different, approach builds on the work of the Comparative Manifesto Project (CMP) that has collected the election manifestos for many parties in many countries and counted the numbers of sentences devoted to 56 different topics (Budge, Klingeman, Volkens, Bara, & Tanenbaum, 2001). Laver and Budge (1993) proposed a way to estimate each party's position on a cross-national left-right scale based on the mentions of various topics (some of which are directional). Kim and Fording (1998, 2002, 2003) then used these party positions¹ to estimate the position of the median voter based on the distribution of party votes and the assumption that each voter voted for the party ideologically closest to him or her. The congruence measure is the distance between the position of the median voter and the median legislator or government, making the same (or similar) assumptions about party unity as discussed earlier.

One advantage of the manifesto approach is that the manifestos are promises made by the parties during election campaigns and have some authenticity as election-specific measures of party positions. On the citizen side too, using the vote takes advantage of a considered behavioral manifestation of citizen preference, which can be seen as more authentic and valid than a response to an abstract survey question. The other great strength of the manifesto approach is that it does measure both median voter and representative on the same scale, one that is designed to be comparable across countries and time periods. Moreover, as we have these data for many countries in all elections since 1946, they permit over time analyses that no other method allows.

A potentially serious problem in the manifesto-based approach lies in the Kim-Fording median voter estimation procedure, which assumes that all voters for a party prefer its ideological position. If voters support a party because they reject the economic failures of the incumbents, or are drawn to its leader, or respond to some special issue appeal, they are nonetheless estimated as preferring its ideology to the others on offer. The median voter estimates thus sometimes show quite a lot of variance from one election to the next when the voters swing in their support for the large parties, which citizen surveys of left-right self-placements seldom show. The attribution of ideological preference for a party to some unknown proportion of voters

voting on nonideological grounds seems likely to overstate the degree of congruence (also see the general critique in Benoit & Laver, 2007).

Citizen identification/citizen perception. This method relies on citizen surveys in which the citizens are asked to place both themselves and each political party on a left-right scale. The positions of legislators and governments are estimated from the party positions in a manner similar to the two other methods. The congruence can be estimated as the distance between median citizen or median voter self-placement (as in the cit-ex method) and the placement of the representatives (less distance equals more congruence). This is the estimation procedure most comparable to the other methods and followed in the tables that follow. However, both Blais and Bodet (2006) and Golder and Stramski (2007) take advantage of the availability of each individual citizen's right-left position also to build a congruence measure based on some kind of average distance (weighted by Golder and Stramski to take account of the variance in voter positions).

The obvious strength of the cit-perc method is that it allows each citizen to interpret his or her own right-left scale content and to place both himself or herself and each party using that self-constructed scale. As in the cit-ex method, it is not necessary that the scale positions be substantively the same across voters, times, and countries, only that the distance metric be similar. The general disadvantage of this method is that it assumes that the citizens are in fact informed about the "true" position of each party. Many citizens may in fact be ignorant about many parties' real right-left positions, certainly more ignorant than the experts, and offering perceptions that are less authentic than manifestos. The citizens may be subject to stereotypes, rationalization of nonideologically based support, projection of their own beliefs, and so forth (also see Merrill, Grofman, & Adams, 2001). They may substitute guesses for informed perceptions; depending on the nature of the guess, various distortions may be introduced. We have to assume that their errors cancel out. It is also assumed that the citizen has a true self-placement on right-left, whereas less involved citizens may place themselves by guessing—even influenced by the party they support. (We can of course use subsets of more informed citizens to make the estimates, as is done by Golder & Stramski, 2007; it turns out that the same results follow.)

Finally, a major problem with this method in practice is that until recently most surveys have not asked citizens to place the parties. The first large, cross-national studies to do this, as far as I know, were the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems project studies, which began only in 1996 and in many countries later. Thus, only recently have we been able to use these

data for comparative congruence analysis, and most important, the data are only available for the recent and limited time frame of elections in the late 1990s and early 2000s.

Election Rules and Congruence: Comparing Methods and Time Periods

Thus, we have three substantially different methods applied to the ideological congruence measurement problem. The challenging Blais and Bodet (2006) and Golder and Stramski (2007) studies are based on different methods, involving a different data set and a different time period. They even involve somewhat different countries, although there is a great deal of overlap. Are the new results, finding no difference between congruence in PR and non-PR systems, a consequence of their different (perhaps superior) method of estimating congruence, getting citizens and parties on the same scale by using citizen perceptions? Or is it the different time period? If the latter, why should that make any difference? I began completely uncertain about the answer but now believe that the critical difference lies in the time periods rather than in the differing balances of advantages and disadvantages of the methods:

Hypothesis 1: The differences in government congruence (distances from median voter on left-right scale) between SMD systems and PR systems will be similar whether measured by manifesto, cit-ex, or cit-perc methods of estimating citizen and government positions.

Hypothesis 1a: Absolute distances will be less (congruence greater) if measured by manifesto method.

Hypothesis 1b: Subsequent hypotheses about causal mechanisms of congruence under SMD and PR will hold (or fail) similarly under all three measurement approaches.

This hypothesis could most clearly be tested by replicating all methods in the same countries and time periods. Unfortunately, we cannot apply the third general method (cit-perc) to the earlier time periods to see if the PR advantage reported by the other approaches would hold with this method also. The data simply are not available. However, we can now extend the other methods (cit-ex and manifesto) into the same time period as the CSES-based cit-perc method—that is, after 1995—and compare all three approaches in this decade. I am glad to report that I was able to replicate the Blais and Bodet (2006) results very closely, with all substantive and significant results

the same, and to replicate the Golder and Stramski (2007) results exactly. So the following results are not based on differences in treatment of the CSES data.²

Table 1 shows the three major methods of estimating citizen and government positions, in the available time period, using the conception of ideological congruence as the distance between the citizen median and the government (this is the concept most widely employed in the previous studies and that is available for comparative analysis³). The first column shows the decade in which the election took place, distinguishing the results in SMD systems and PR systems (the specific classification of systems is shown in the note to the table). The next column shows the congruence results in that decade from SMD and PR systems, using the manifesto method, whose data are now available from 1946 through 2003 (Budge et al., 2001; Klingemann et al., 2006⁴). These congruence estimates are based on a 0 to 100 scale, where 0 is a manifesto based purely on rightist ideological statements and 100 is a manifesto based purely on leftist ideological statements. The third column shows the congruence results using the cit-ex method, updated using CSES citizen surveys and an expert study by Benoit and Laver (2006). The fourth column uses the cit-perc method from the CSES surveys. In the latter two columns the absolute values have been converted to a 100-point scale so that we can compare the absolute differences across methods.⁵

The results of the comparative analyses in Table 1 are quite clear. Reading down the decades for the manifesto results we see that in four decades the PR systems have a clear congruence advantage (smaller distances), usually a statistically significant one, as predicted by the previous literature. In two decades—1956-1965 and 1996-2004—the SMD systems do slightly better. Similarly, in the smaller number of decades available for the cit-ex results, we see that in the two decades of 1976-1985 and 1986-1995 the PR systems have a clear congruence advantage—but not in the most recent decade. Finally, we see that with the cit-perc results, available only for the past decade, our findings match those of Blais and Bodet (2006) and Golder and Stramski (2007)—no PR advantage. Thus, the three methods show similar results within comparable time periods. It seems to be the time period, not the different methods, that are associated with the varying PR-SMD advantage, consistent with Hypothesis 1.

Two other points are worth making about the data in Table 1. First, we see in the long manifesto time period, the distances in the PR systems are roughly comparable from decade to decade, showing a slight decline over time. What changes sharply across decades are the distances in the SMD

Table 1
Government Ideological Congruence in Proportional Representation (PR) and Single Member District (SMD) Systems: By Time Period and Estimation Method^a

Election		Ideological Distance: Median Citizen and Government					
Decade	Election Rules	Manifesto Method	N	Citizen-Expert	N	Citizen Perception	N
1945–1955	PR	12.4	43	—			
	SMD	15.2	16	—			
1956–1965	PR	9.0	38	—			
	SMD	7.8	15	—			
1966–1975	PR	10.5	38	—			
	SMD	11.8	19	—			
1976–1985	PR	7.9	47	13.7	27	—	
	SMD	13.1	14	18.9	10	—	
1986–1995	PR	6.9	46	10.1	33	—	
	SMD	15.7	12	18.6	10		
1996–2004	PR	8.0	31	13.4	22	13.0	28
	SMD	5.9	9	10.9	7	9.4	7
Total	PR	9.1	243	12.2	82	13.0	28
	SMD	11.9	85	16.7	27	9.4	7

a. In the manifesto data set the 85 SMD elections are in Australia, Britain, Canada, New Zealand (through 1993), and France after 1956 and not in 1986; the 243 PR elections are in Austria, Belgium, Denmark, Finland, France (1946-1956 and 1986), Germany, Iceland, Ireland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, New Zealand (1996, 1999, 2001), Norway, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland. Italy is counted as PR, although in 1994, 1996, and 2001 the majority of seats were SMD with only partial compensation. In the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) data set the 7 SMD elections are in Australia, Britain, Canada, and France; the 28 PR elections are in Belgium, Denmark, Finland, Germany, Iceland, Ireland, Israel, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, and Switzerland. In all tables the manifesto data estimate the median voter position, whereas the other methods estimate the median citizen position.

systems. Another point is that if we look at the absolute distances, we see that the magnitudes are rather similar in the cit-ex and cit-perc data but substantially smaller in the manifesto data. We suspected that the manifesto data might understate absolute distances (overstate congruence), and that is consistent with what we see (Hypothesis 1a). However, the relative differences between SMD and PR are quite similar with all three methods. (These results also hold using congruence with the median legislator rather than the government, although the relative PR advantage in each decade is larger.)

Theoretical Underpinnings and Causal Mechanisms

We can enhance our confidence in the basic comparability of measures with respect to the SMD–PR difference and also address theoretical arguments made by recent studies by explicating the causal mechanisms connecting election rules and ideological congruence. There is considerable agreement about these and we are freed to some extent from dependence on particular measurement assumptions if we can trace the same mechanisms with different measures. Roughly similar general formulations are offered by Huber and Powell (1994), Cox (1997), McDonald and Budge (2005, chapter 7), Blais and Bodet (2006), and Golder and Stramski (2007).

First, all these works on ideological congruence assume dominance of a unidimensional issue space, usually called the right-left scale, which is the metric for comparing citizens and representatives. (Obviously, this critical assumption that the right-left dimension captures all the critical issues in elections that link citizens and representatives is more accurate in some countries than others, even in the developed, “old” democracies.) These studies usually assume that the appropriate conception of congruence is between the median citizen (whose position can theoretically defeat any other single position in one-dimensional voting competition) and the government.⁶ Better ideological correspondence occurs when the position of the government is closer to that of the median citizen.

Second, we can understand citizen-government congruence as the outcome of two causal processes: party competition and government formation. Let us consider government formation first: It directs our attention to the relevant parties and there is a large amount of theoretical and empirical agreement about how its processes work. SMD election rules are associated with fewer political parties (Duverger’s Law) and greater vote-seat distortion in the aggregation of votes, with the combination very often resulting in legislative majorities for single political parties (Lijphart, 1994; Rae, 1967).⁷

Hypothesis 2: Government formation under SMD election rules is usually dominated by the plurality vote-winning party.

Hypothesis 2a: Government congruence under SMD is usually determined by the distance between the median voter and the plurality vote winner.

PR election rules are associated with more political parties and (unless there are too many parties for the carrying capacity of the system) more accurate reflection of votes into legislative seats. Single party legislative majorities

are common under SMD election rules but very rare under PR election rules. Some kind of legislative majority is needed to form and sustain a government in the parliamentary systems. Therefore after the election, some kind of bargaining between political parties is needed to create a reliable majority to sustain the government. Postelection legislative bargaining to form a government should give an important role to the median legislative party, perhaps allowing it to dominate coalition formation (most famously, Laver & Schofield, 1990, p. 111). The largest legislative party (usually the plurality vote winner under PR) is also very important in the coalition-building process (Laver & Schofield, 1990; Martin & Stevenson, 2001). Although there are many nuances here (i.e., the roles of preelection coalitions and minority governments), various empirical studies generally support this sketch of the different causal processes, and most analyses of ideological congruence build on them.

Hypothesis 3: Government formation under PR election rules is shaped by the median legislative party and the plurality vote-winning party.

Hypothesis 3a: Government congruence under PR is usually shaped by the distances between the median voter and (a) the median legislative party and (b) the plurality vote winner.

There is general theoretical agreement that both of these processes can under some circumstances create close ideological congruence. That is, close ideological congruence can be expected under some conditions under both SMD and PR election rules. The processes of party competition that determine the distance between the median voter and the different political parties are critical to congruence in either system although, as suggested in Hypotheses 2 and 3, the parties are somewhat different.

Under SMD, ideological congruence can be expected when one or both of the two largest political parties take a position close to that of the median voter. According to Duverger (1954), the party system should reduce toward two-party competition under SMD, at least at the district level. According to the theory associated with the work of Anthony Downs (1957), such convergence to the median should occur routinely in two-party competition in a one-dimensional issue space. (Other theoretical work has suggested that even with more dimensions, such convergence might emerge.)

Hypothesis 4a: Under SMD election rules, party competition should lead the plurality vote winner to be close to the median voter.

Under PR, ideological convergence can be expected when one of the competing parties takes a position fairly close to the median voter, which should

happen under the multiparty competition expected under PR (Cox, 1990, 1997), and then becomes the median legislative party under the accurate vote-seat representation also associated with PR.⁸ (This party could be the plurality vote winner but often is not.) However, the distance of the coalition may also be affected by the plurality party if these are not the same. We have no clear expectations about the distance of the plurality vote winner under PR, but absent the centripetal dynamics of two-party competition, it should on average be further than under SMD. (Some authors, such as Blais & Bodet, 2006, expect more party system diversity of choice under PR, as well as convergence under SMD, thus see these dynamics as favoring congruence under SMD.)

Hypothesis 4b: Under PR election rules, party competition and accurate vote-seat aggregation should lead the median legislative party to be close to the median voter. The plurality vote winner, if different, should be further away from the median voter.

The disagreement in most of the work on ideological congruence concerns how frequently we should expect each of these contrasting processes of electoral convergence under SMD and median party-dominated negotiation under PR to succeed or fail. Gary Cox (1997), in his summary theoretical analysis, argues that it

depends on what one assumes about coordination. If coordination is more likely to fail at the electoral stage, then stronger systems will be more erratic. If coordination is more likely to fail at the government formation stage, then feebler systems will be more erratic. (p. 237)

Proponents of SMD systems believe that the party convergence process will be more reliable than elite bargaining (e.g., Pinto-Duschinsky, 1999). Proponents of PR tend to stress the stringency of the conditions that are necessary for the convergence under SMD (Pinto-Duschinsky, Powell, Lijphart, Vowles, & Shugart, 1999; on the theoretical stringency of these conditions or the impact of deviation from them, see Cox, 1997, chapter 12; Grofman, 2004; Powell, 2006; Powell & Vanberg, 2000, especially on the geographic complexities).

However, some analysts see no reason to expect one mechanism to be advantaged over the other (Golder & Stramski, 2007) and/or see offsetting processes (Blais & Bodet, 2006). Thus, Blais and Bodet (2006) present evidence that (in the CSES data in the most recent decade) general convergence of the parties is helpful to the SMD systems, whereas multiparty coalition governments are helpful to PR systems, with the two effects roughly canceling each other.

Neither set of theorists expects different results in different time periods. However, we could formulate a hypothesis about relative system advantage in those terms:

Hypothesis 5: In time periods when the plurality vote winners are close to the median under SMD, the SMD systems will have better congruence because the need to add another party (e.g., the plurality party) under PR will pull the government further away. In time periods when the plurality vote winners are no closer to the median voter under SMD than PR, the PR systems will have better congruence because the legislative median party will pull the governments towards the median voter.

Causal Processes in SMD Systems: Plurality Winners and Convergence

We can further enhance our confidence that the results for the most recent decade are not the consequence of measurement differences by explicating the causal processes that shape ideological congruence (see Keman, 2007). As sketched in Hypotheses 2 and 2a, we expect that in the SMD systems the creation of congruence emerges from the effect of party competition on the campaign promises of the two largest political parties. The combination of Duvergerian and Downsian predictions leads us to expect that under SMD the number of parties will be reduced toward two-party competition and that two-party competition will lead the parties to converge on the position of the median voter. When this happens, close ideological congruence will be created, regardless of which large party actually wins the election. If one of the large parties takes a position close to the median voter and the other does not, the process still creates good ideological congruence as long as that party wins the election. On the other hand, if threats from additional parties, or the pressures of party activists, or other factors lead to a failure of large parties to converge on the median voter or if a coordination failure of some kind leads the more distant party to win, then ideological congruence may be diminished. As Grofman's (2004) review suggests, the Downsian assumptions are actually rather strong, and many factors may inhibit convergence. (Also see the discussion of the complicating role of local-national competitive relationships given single member geographic districts in Powell & Vanberg, 2000.)

Hypothesis 5 leads us to expect that the distance between the plurality vote winner and the median voter will account for varying government distances in different time periods and potentially for differences between

Table 2
Regression Analyses: Distance Between Median Voter
and Government in SMD Systems, Two Methods

Independent Variables	Ideological Distance: Median Voter and Government			
	Manifesto Method		Cit-Expert Method	
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 1	Model 2
Constant	15.2 (2.0)**	3.4 (1.1)**	18.9 (1.6)**	5.1 (1.8)
1956–1965	–7.3 (2.8)**	–1.7 (1.3)	—	—
1966–1975	–3.4 (2.7)	–2.6 (1.3)*	—	—
1976–1985	–2.1 (2.8)	–.2 (1.3)	—	—
1986–1995	.6 (2.9)	.6 (1.2)	–.3 (2.3)	–1.3 (1.3)
1996–2003	–9.3 (3.0)**	–2.5 (1.8)	–8.0 (3.2)*	–.0 (1.7)
Plurality party distance to median voter	—	0.84 (0.05)**	—	.77 (.08)**
R-squared	.15	.77	.18	0.81
N of cases	85	85	27	27

Note: 1945–1955 is omitted dummy variable reference category in the Manifesto Method. 1976–1985 is the omitted dummy variable reference category in the Cit-Ex Method. Panel-corrected standard errors in parentheses. ** is significant at .01; * sig at .05

SMD and PR advantage. Table 2 shows regression analyses of the distance between the median voter and the government in SMD systems, using the manifesto method in the two left columns and the cit-ex method in the two right columns. On the far left we see the independent variables, which are simple dummy variables for each of the 10-year periods. The 1945–1955 period is omitted as a reference baseline. In the first data column we see only the time periods as independent variables. As we might expect from Table 1, two decades stand out as having significantly less distance between median voter and government than the reference period: 1956–1965 and 1996–2005. In the next column, we enter a variable for the distance between the median voter and the plurality vote winner. In that specification, only the plurality vote winner distance is (very strongly) statistically significant, whereas the time dummies are reduced, most to insignificance.

In the two right columns we see comparable results for the three decades of cit-ex measures for which we have data. Very similarly, the most recent decade is significantly negative in the time regression (with the 1976–1985

as baseline), but the time effects vanish after entering the distance between plurality winner and median voter. These results strongly support Hypothesis 2a, about the causal process under SMD, and also the measurement consistency expectation of Hypothesis 1—but are contrary to the consistent SMD convergence that is the underpinning of Hypothesis 4a.

It is satisfying to confirm our theoretical expectation that the variation in government distance in the SMD systems is largely the consequence of variation in the distance of the plurality vote winner. This shows the importance of the convergence mechanism for ideological correspondence in SMD systems. Although the over-time analysis cannot be as satisfactorily replicated with the other measurement methods, because we do not have them over time, we can within each approach show that the distance of the plurality winner is a powerful predictor of distance between government and citizens. Indeed, when converted to the same metric, the regression coefficients are quite similar. This further supports the argument that it is not differences in measuring the positions of median voters and parties that is responsible for the differing results in the most recent decade.

However, we still do not know why these two decades of 1956-1965 and 1996-2005 manifest such distinctive convergence to the median voter in a number of SMD systems. (It is perhaps no coincidence that it was with reference to the mid-1950s that Downs, 1957, proposed the theory of convergence to the median voter.) Looking at the individual countries, the convergence is especially notable in those two decades compared to the others in Britain and Australia; the 1956-1965 decade stands out less distinctively in France (during the early 5th Republic), Canada, and New Zealand, although other decades have greater distances. (Interestingly enough, in the United States the most recent elections are not distinctively depolarized, with 1992 and 1996, the Clinton elections, showing below average polarization but 2000 being fairly typical.)

The kinds of factors proposed by Kitschelt (1994), or that emerge from the Grofman (2004) general review, or suggested by the May's Law work (Kitschelt, 1989; May, 1973; Norris, 1995) to explain failure of some large parties to seek the median voter cannot easily be explored with these data; neither can the kind of geographic, local-national issues raised by Powell and Vanberg (2000). The best known recent case of this phenomenon, that of Britain in 1997, is usually explained in the local context by the victory of moderates, after a long struggle, in gaining control of the Labour Party, suppressing their leftist opponents, transforming name (New Labour), party constitution, and manifesto promises. In the British case the long period in opposition seemed to play a major role.

Two-Stage Causal Processes in PR Systems: Electing a Legislature and Negotiating a Government

It would be reassuring for our understanding of the problems and advantages of alternative methods of measuring ideological congruence to find evidence of comparable processes in the PR systems as we did in the SMD systems. Table 3 shows the result of regression analyses predicting the distance between the median voter and the government in PR systems. In each equation the two independent variables are the distance to the median legislative party and the distance to the plurality party, as predicted by Hypotheses 3 and 3a. In the left-hand column we see the analysis using the manifesto data for the full time period for which we have data, followed by a replication of that analysis in the most recent time period only. In the third column we see the analysis using the CSES cit-perc data, which covers of course only the most recent time period. In the fourth column we see the analysis using the cit-expert method for 82 cases, covering the period from about 1978 to 2003 (but with some missing elections due to absence of data).

The results in Table 3 are encouragingly consistent with Hypotheses 3 and 3a and the three methods yield fairly similar results (Hypothesis 1b). Of course, we know that we are not taking account of some other important factors, especially the presence of preelection coalition commitments (Golder, 2006; Martin & Stevenson, 2001; Powell, 2000). Nonetheless, the distance between median voter and the median legislative party is statistically significant with all three methods, as is the distance between median voter and the plurality party. The magnitudes of effect are fairly similar in the different time periods for the manifesto analysis and roughly similar with the other two methods. In general, one point greater distance of either the plurality party or the median legislative party from the median voter increases the government distance by a third to a half of a point.

Comparing Congruence Processes Under PR and SMD

In principle we could put our analyses of the way party systems and election rules shape ideological congruence together by way of an interactive regression equation, entering the two party variables shown in Table 3 (distance of the plurality party and distance of the legislative median party) directly and as interaction terms with the election rules. However, the problem is that in the handful of SMD system cases in the most recent time period (nine in the

Table 3
Regression Analyses: Distance Between
Median Voter and Government in PR Systems
(Three Alternative Measurement Methods)

Independent Variables	Ideological Distance: Median Voter/Citizen and Gov			
	Manifesto Method		Cit Perception (CSES)	Citizen-Expert
	1945–2003	1996–2003	1996–2004	1978–2003
Constant	4.24 (.82)**	3.27 (.94)**	-.48 (2.58)	3.06 (1.43)*
Legislative median distance to median voter/citizen	.37 (.12)**	.45 (.08)**	.57 (.23)**	.37 (.12)**
Plurality party distance to median voter/citizen	.30 (.05)**	.31 (.06)**	.52 (.13)**	.41 (.12)**
R-squared	.19	.41	.60	.43
N of cases	243	31	28	82

Note: Panel-corrected standard errors in parentheses. ** is significant at .01; * sig at .05

manifesto data and seven in the CSES data), these variables are all highly correlated. Legislative distance and government distance are correlated at .99, whereas the plurality winner is correlated with each of them at .90 or more. We cannot realistically partition the different effects, as we could in the PR systems, as shown in Table 3, where the plurality party and the median legislative party each contribute independently to the position of the government.

However, we can demonstrate the difference between the government formation processes between the two systems (and the equivalence of the measurement methods) in the equations shown in Table 4. These simply present the relationship between median legislative party distance from the median voter and government distance from the median voter with the three methods. The first column shows the results from the manifesto method applied to the full postwar time period. The second column shows the manifesto method applied only in the most recent decade. The third column shows the CSES data and the citi-perc method. The fourth column shows the cit-ex method in the 1978–2003 periods (109 cases). We have already seen in Table 1 that without taking account of any of the political party distances, the PR systems have closer (and statistically significant) congruence across

Table 4
Regression Analyses: Distance Between
Median Voter and Government All Systems
(Three Alternative Measurement Methods)

Independent Variables	Ideological Distance: Median Voter/Citizen and Gov			
	Manifesto Method		Cit Perception (CSES)	Citizen- Expert
	1945–2003	1996–2003	1996–2004	1978–2003
Constant	6.68 (.81)**	6.02 (.75)**	6.45 (2.36)**	7.40 (1.13)**
SMD election rules	–4.68 (1.13)**	–6.27 (.40)**	–6.34 (1.87)**	–4.71 (1.90)*
Legislative median distance to median voter/citizen	.57 (.13)**	.55 (.12)**	.71 (.33)*	0.57 (.11)**
Leg Med * SMD	.35 (.14)*	.80 (.11)**	.34 (.27)	.33 (.14)*
R-squared	.26	.47	.42	.45
N of cases	328	40	35	109

Note: Panel-corrected standard errors in parentheses. ** is significant at .01; * sig at .05.

the full time periods covered by the manifesto and cit-ex data and that by all methods there are no significant differences in the most recent time period.

As these are interactive equations, we must interpret the coefficients carefully. The negative coefficients for the election rules themselves mean that in all four equations, if the legislative median party were right at the median voter/citizen (distance is zero), the governments in the SMD systems would actually be significantly advantaged. This would be the ideal Duverger-Downs convergence case, which is not (contrary to Hypothesis 4a) often realized across the full set of SMD cases. But the result is theoretically encouraging and supports Hypothesis 5.

The coefficient for legislative distance is here the effect in the PR systems only, which as we see is strong and significant in all four equations (.57, .55, .71, .57), one point greater distance between legislative median party and the median voter is consistently associated with PR governments about a half point further from the median. The interaction term is the additional impact of the median legislative party in the SMD systems, which is itself usually significant (although not in the CSES data, but with few cases and a similar coefficient). It shows that the legislative median is more dominant of government formation in the SMD systems. This significance

is consistent with our expectation that there are often one-party majorities in the SMD legislatures, which both contain the legislative median and form the government (also see the discussion of majoritarian and proportional ideals in Powell, 2000, p. 126).

Finally, the effect in the SMD systems is seen by adding the legislative distance and the interaction coefficient—in all the equations this sum is very close to 1. In SMD systems, the distance of the median legislative party translates into government distances in a one-to-one correspondence (0.92, 1.35, 1.05, 0.90), and these combined coefficients are all significant. Despite some differences, the large picture seems to be one of very considerable consistency of the government formation processes across the diverse methods and times. However, the frequent failure of the Duverger-Downs party convergence hypothesis under SMD leads to varying outcomes at different time periods (as we saw in Table 2).

Concluding Observations

As usual in empirical research, we can answer some questions only to raise others. Here, the initial question was whether the recent analyses of CSES data that showed no difference in ideological congruence between SMD and PR systems (Blais & Bodet, 2006; Golder & Stramski, 2007)—in contrast to several sets of previous findings—were due to the putatively superior data for estimating congruence, alternative conceptions and measures, or the different time period covered.

The answer to the initial question seems quite clear: It's the time frame. Golder and Stramski (2007) already showed that various conceptions of ideological congruence using the CSES data (1996-2004) all showed no significant difference between SMD and PR, a conclusion with which we agree. Our contribution was to extend the other principal approaches and data sets for measuring congruence into the recent period so that we can then compare across time periods. Our analysis shows clearly that while in most decades the PR systems have a substantial advantage in legislative ideological congruence and a smaller but still significant advantage in government ideological congruence, this advantage completely vanishes in 1996-2004 with all methods. We also show that analyses of causal mechanisms under SMD and PR in Tables 2 through 4 hold up with several different data sets and approaches to measuring congruence.

Moreover, the analysis shows that the average levels of ideological congruence in the PR systems are roughly consistent across decades; it is the average

congruence in the SMD systems that varies over time. It is the presence or absence of convergence of the largest party toward the position of the median voter that accounts for the great bulk of the variance in SMD congruence in all time periods. In SMD systems the Downsian prediction of convergence of the largest party to the median voter frequently (although not always) fails. When it does, the conversion of plurality votes into absolute legislative majorities in these systems results in legislative medians and governments well away from the median voter (see also Powell & Vanberg, 2000).

It is not clear why the (Duverger-Downs) prediction of convergence in the SMD systems has worked so much more successfully in a number of SMD elections in the past decade (as it did to some extent in the 1956-1965 decade). From the Duverger-Downs hypotheses we might expect it to be related to the number of competing political parties, but within the SMD systems there is no significant relationship between the effective number of parties and the distance of the plurality party from the median voter ($r = .06$). The British experience of 1997 and after seems to suggest that such convergence has more to do with competing pressures from party activists within the parties. This is an area that will require further investigation. At the moment we do not know if the 1996-2004 decade represents a random fluctuation (of the few SMD elections), the outcome of short-term global or ideological context, or a trend.

Unlike the government and legislative distances in the SMD systems, which are overwhelmingly determined by the distance of the plurality party, the government, distances in the PR systems are shaped by both the plurality party distance and the (usually much lesser) distance of the legislative median party (see Tables 3 and 4). This process is satisfyingly consistent with basic theoretical expectations.

The plurality party distance from the median is similar, on average, in the SMD and PR systems, with lots of variation within each (according to the manifesto data). However, the government distances in PR are usually reduced by the role of the legislative median party (or cross-median coalitions), creating, it seems, the usual PR advantage. The median voter and median legislative party are usually quite close under PR.

However, it is also worth pointing out that the percentage of variance in government ideological congruence explained in the PR systems by the distances from the plurality party and the legislative median party over the long time span covered by the manifesto data is not very great ($R^2 = .19$ in Table 3). So there are clearly other factors not being taken into account. We have yet to determine whether these have primarily to do with preelection coalitions (as suggested by Martin & Stevenson, 2001; Powell, 2006),

which may alter the coalition formation process, or by coordination failures at the legislative level (Cox, 1997, chapter 12), or by other factors.

The processes that shape ideological congruence between the median citizen and the government are somewhat different under PR election rules and SMD election rules. PR congruence largely depends on a two-stage process of electoral competition and party negotiation, usually involving the largest party and the legislative median party. SMD congruence is dominated by the electoral competition between the large parties and the vote-seat distortion that creates majorities. The encouraging message of this article is that we can observe these different processes in our statistical analysis using a variety of different methods of measuring party positions and voter positions and over a substantial period of time. This is both theoretically and empirically pleasing. (However, I would not want to overstate the similarity of the methods for all analytic purposes. See Keman, 2007.)

Which electoral system offers voters the advantage in producing ideological congruence depends on the relative successes and failures of these somewhat different processes. We do not have a powerful, unified theory that enables us to predict their relative rates of success and failure, although we can identify the weak points of each. We have only the conjecture that the conditions for congruence under SMD may be more stringent, in the sense that failure of one key party (the plurality party) to converge toward the median has large consequences. This is presumably due to the magnifying effect of vote-seat disproportionality, present in all of our SMD systems, as well as the smaller number of parties. Ordinarily, no single party's behavior has such large consequences under PR.

Notes

1. Among members of the CMP, there are some differences about the exact creation of these party estimates. I use here the approach of Kim and Fording (1998), which takes the difference between left and right statements, divided by the total number of statements classified as right or left (on support for this approach see Benoit & Laver, 2007, p. 96; Gabel & Huber, 2000).

2. All the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) analyses reported here are based on the "old democracies," excluding the new Eastern European cases. (See the note to Table 1 for the exact countries classified as proportional representation [PR] and single member district [SMD] electoral systems.)

3. Measures using average voter-government distances will be affected by the distribution of the voters, so some control for that distribution is needed. As Golder and Stramski (2007) already report, despite what could be great differences in correspondence emerging from alternative conceptions, the "traditional" approach of comparing median voter and government yields results similar to the approaches based on average distances of individual voters (if controlled by citizen variance). Not only do these various methods all result in no significant

difference between PR and SMD systems in the period covered by the CSES studies, but they are in fact highly correlated, around .80.

4. Thanks to HeeMin Kim for providing his estimates of the median voter position and each party's position using the manifesto data and also for providing data on the allocation of cabinet portfolios.

5. In the manifesto and CSES data, the parties in the government are weighted by their proportion of cabinet portfolios; in the citizen survey/expert survey (cit-ex) data, the parties are weighted by their percentage of legislative seats. In the manifesto data the distance is between the (first) government and the median voter; in the CSES and cit-ex data the distance is between the (first) government and the median citizen.

6. From a normative point of view, this is a measure especially appropriate for the majoritarian vision of representative democracy and relevant but incomplete for proponents of the proportional vision (see Powell, 2000, pp. 165-166).

7. Of course, it's more complicated than this in practice, as the particular variations of SMD in Australia and France encourage more parties and preelection coalitions, and sometimes even in SMD no single party wins a majority, usually followed by a minority government of the party winning the legislative plurality.

8. The variance in citizen preference distribution could also affect this distance between closest party and median voter (holding the number of parties constant). If citizens in PR systems were less ideologically dispersed, this could make it easier to achieve closer congruence. However, Golder and Stramski (2007) report that in the CSES data and in Eurobarometer and World Value studies the citizens in PR systems are more ideologically dispersed than citizens in the majoritarian systems, which could hinder their ideological congruence.

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G. Bingham Powell, Jr. is Marie C. and Joseph C. Wilson Professor of political science at the University of Rochester. He is the author of *Elections as Instruments of Democracy: Majoritarian and Proportional Visions* (Yale, 2000) and *Contemporary Democracies: Participation, Stability and Violence* (Harvard, 1982).